# Claude Code for Accounting Research

Module 6 — Seminar: AI, the Production of Knowledge, and the Academic Research Market

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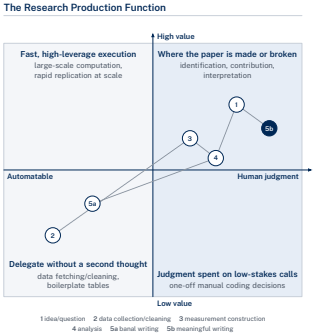
Yale School of Management

# The Week, With a Price Tag

| Module | What you built | This week | ∼2019 |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | R&D-intensity panel, SEC FSDS | 80 min lab | RA, ∼1 week |
| 3 | EDGAR risk-factor pipeline + reusable skill | 80 min lab | RA, 2–3 weeks |
| 4 | Filtered, verified Compustat `funda` pull | 80 min lab | RA, several days |
| 5 | Hardened, rerunnable repo: paper trail, git | ∼3 hrs | RA, days of audit |

That speed-up raises a question that is not technical.

# Place Your Dissertation on This Map

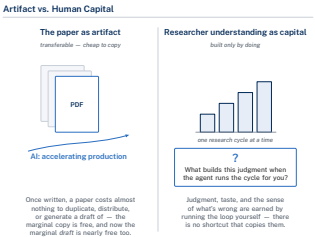



Pipeline stages $\times$ automatable$\leftrightarrow$human-judgment $\times$ low$\leftrightarrow$high value.

## Do this now, on your own

Place your own dissertation's stages on this map. Don't discuss yet. Block 1 opens with two volunteers defending their placement.

# The Artifact and the Capital




Artifact: transferable, cheap to copy. Capital: built only by doing the work.

## The personal audit

Can you discuss it without the LLM? Macnamara et al.: AI takes over the sub-tasks where expertise gets built. Gerlich: heavier AI use goes with weaker critical thinking; more education raises the level regardless of AI use.

# Provenance: Who Is Accountable?

*"A computer can never be held accountable."*
*— IBM training manual, 1979*

**_Nature_'s two rules (2023)**

1. No LLM will be credited as an author. Authorship carries accountability a model cannot take on.
2. Any use of these tools must be documented

# A Retraction, Not a Citation

## Retraction case study: labeled as such, never cited as evidence

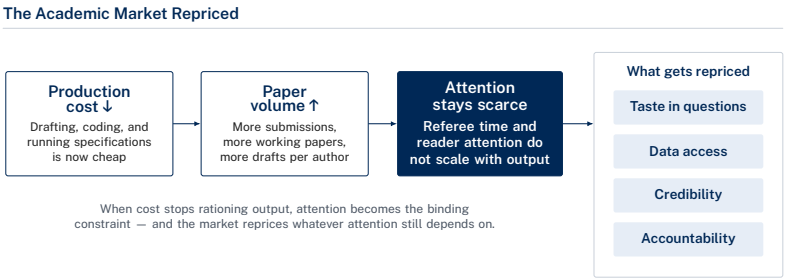
A 2024 working paper claimed that a randomized rollout of an AI materials-discovery tool raised researcher output 44%

- Circulated to acclaim from prominent economists, then MIT said it had “no confidence in the provenance, reliability or validity of the data”
- MIT asked for the paper to be withdrawn; the author is no longer at MIT
- The field’s provenance-checking machinery failed *before* AI was writing papers

## The open question

Does AI make that machinery stronger (audit trails) or weaker (volume)?

# Papers Are the Currency




Placement, tenure, prestige, salary all clear through publications. Bloom, Jones, Van Reenen & Webb (2020): ideas are getting harder to find. Lusher, Yang & Carrell (2023): more working papers the same week $\rightarrow$ worse outcomes for each, not just the weak ones.

# Rules of Engagement

- Three blocks, $\sim$30 min each, with a 5-min stretch between
- Each block: 2-min position statements (assigned Module 5) $\rightarrow$ open discussion $\rightarrow$ instructor synthesis
- No catastrophizing and no dismissing: pair every provocation with its counterargument
- Memo due one week after today

# Block 1 — Knowledge vs. Learning

- If AI produces the artifact, what happens to the learning?
- Opens with your dissertation placement; two volunteers defend theirs
- Which pipeline stages build intuition worth protecting?
- Accounting parallel: AI-assisted audit judgment

**Closing question**

Is PhD training a production process, or a transformation of the student?

# Block 2 — Man vs. Machine

- Does it matter, epistemically or socially, who or what produced a result?
- Two identical extractions, one hand-coded by an RA and one from Claude with an audit trail. Are they equivalent?
- A spotless audit trail can still deliver a wrong estimate
- 10-min segment: when a second model reviews the first model's code, what is verified?

**Closing question**

Does AI make the field's provenance-checking machinery stronger or weaker?

# Block 3 — Returns to Research

- Papers are the currency. What happens when production costs collapse?
- You built the Module 4 pipeline in an 80-minute lab. Suppose every accounting PhD can.
- Scarce candidates: question taste, data access and institutional knowledge, credibility, accountability
- Homogenization: if every referee report passes through the same models, does voice still signal anything?

## Closing question

Name one input you believe stays scarce. That answer is the starting point for your memo.

# The Memo

## "What I will still be paid for in 2036": one page, due in one week

- Commit to specific components of the research production function that stay human
- Defend with one course reading *and* one experience from the build modules
- Name one concrete investment for your remaining PhD years

## Grading

Credit/no-credit on **defended specificity**. An optimist and a pessimist can both earn credit; a vague memo cannot.